DMC welcome letter

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Attachments: DMC_syllabus.pdf, DMC_preface.pdf, DMC_notes_on_notes.pdf

Hello everybody,

Welcome to BOLLI class "Tales of Defiance to Mind Control in the Modern Age," HG19-LIT-5b-Mon2-F26, or "DMC" for short. I am looking forward to our learning together.

We meet in person on Mondays during Period 2 (11:10 a.m. to 12:35 p.m.) at 51 Sawyer Road, second floor. Our class meets on November 2, 9, 16, 23, and 30.

Please feel free to contact me at axelrod@alumni.princeton.edu with comments, questions, requests for clarification or help, or to let me know if you will be late or absent for a class.

To help me verify that everyone's email address works and to begin getting to know one another, please reply to this note with a brief email to me only. Be careful not to press "reply to all". Please includes your name, the town where you live, what sparked your interest in taking this class, and any background information you would like to share. If you are comfortable doing so, please include a picture of yourself to help me connect faces with names. Please also indicate if there is any information in your response that you do not want me to share with the class. I will combine the authorized information into a single email, which I plan to send to the class on November 1.

For each of the first four weeks, we will focus on a different tale of defiance to mind control. The final week will be devoted to discussion of the arc of all four stories as a whole.

Website

Here is a link to the course website: course website. Parts of the website are under construction, but all the materials needed to prepare for Week 1 are available now.

With the exception of personal information about students, such as the information in the "single email" mentioned above, all class materials will be accessible from the website.

The website has a header and a page that appears in a frame below the header. The header has a dropdown box in the upper left that allows one to select the page that appears in the frame below the header.

Email

I will send all essential materials (other than the films to watch) by email. When I email links to course website pages, I will send links to the standalone pages, without the course header.

An Arc of Stories and Lenses

Each of the four stories we will explore could be the basis of one or more full courses. Combining them means we won't be able to cover the individual stories in great depth, but it will allow us to see an example of what I call *an* arc of dystopian stories. For each story, I will suggest a tool or "lens" we can use to examine it. These lenses are intended to foster thinking and discussion, not to create a barrier of abstraction.

Week 1 Homework

Here is the homework to prepare for our first class. The three readings can be viewed by clicking on the links or by opening the attached pdf files.

- Read the Course Syllabus
  - Check that you will have access to the three films in the Course Materials section.
- Read the Preface to the Course, which consists of sections:
  1. Genesis of the Course: Getting Perspective on Mind Control
  2. Shaping the Container
  3. What We Will Be Exploring
  4. An Arc of Stories and Lenses
     - You may delay reading the parts on the tales for weeks 2, 3, and 4, which will be repeated as part of the notes on the tale of the week.
- Read the Notes on *Notes from the Underground*.
  - This contains a section titled "Tale 1: Notes from the Underground", which exactly repeats the subsection by that name in section 4 of the preface.
- Watch "Notes from the Underground", one-man show starring Larry Cedar, free on YouTube.



Questions

Here are some questions that may help guide your reflection. They are all about the protagonist in *Notes from the Underground*, who is not given a name in the story, but is conventionally referred to as the Underground Man.

Concrete Questions about the Underground Man

- What is his situation?
- How did he get into it?
- What was his dilemma?
- What about his personality might have caused him difficulty?

More Abstract/Subjective Questions in Preface Section on *Notes from the Underground* and Human Outlier Analysis

- How is the protagonist unusual in the society in which they live, and how are they trying to influence that society?
- Do you sympathize with the protagonist and his plight? What about the other characters?
- Can we usefully separate out the dysfunction from the creative insight?
- What does the protagonist see about society that those around him do not see?

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I look forward to hearing from you and seeing you in class. I encourage you to defy my attempts to control your mind with suggestions, arguments, and even complaints.

Take care,
Scott Axelrod
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